think any of us could really imagine life at United without Alex Ferguson in charge. Players would have arguments with him: I definitely wasn't the only one. And, in whatever walk of life, when you're in the middle of a dispute with your boss, you wish he wasn't your boss. Most of the time, though, if you ask any United player they'll tell you that working for the manager means you're working for the best in the world.

The day I arrived at Manchester United, as a teenager away from home for the first time, the boss knew my name. He knew my mum and dad, and my sisters. He knew everything about me. And he made me feel welcome. It was as if I was leaving one family and joining another. That's a great strength in any manager: to make players feel like he knows and understands and cares about them. Look how the manager hung on for Ruud van Nistelrooy, stayed in touch with him all through his comeback from rupturing his cruciate ligaments. He kept reassuring him that he would come to Old Trafford eventually. Players recognize that kind of loyalty. No wonder Ruud paid him back with all those goals to help United win the Premiership in 2003.

The boss has always known how to make the new boy feel at home from day one. Even more important is that, once that relationship has been established, you never feel he'd turn his back on it. Like a father, the United manager was there to protect you, advise you and give you a piece of his mind for as long as you were part of the family; as long as you were part of the club. Young hopefuls and established stars: the boss makes them all feel special, and he makes sure they realize how special the club is. There have been players, like Dwight Yorke or Jaap Stam, who've done great things for United, but who suddenly found themselves on the outside without a way back. Something they said or did had convinced the manager they weren't right for the club. In the end, maybe I turned out to be one of those players too even though, at the start of the 2001/02 season, I'd never have imagined that happening.

By reputation, the Manchester United manager is short-tempered and miserable. Well, the boss is both from time to time. But then, isn't everybody? What people outside the dressing room never see is how inspiring he can be when he's working with players. They don't see him, either, when he's having a laugh and a joke with the lads. When he thinks it's right, he does relax when he's around the team. If the dressing room's buzzing after a great win, he'll be wearing the biggest grin of the lot. I'd say the boss is right in keeping a professional distance from his players most of the time. He's careful not to be closer to one lad than to another, even if his relationships with one or two, like Eric Cantona or Roy Keane, were always different from the rest.